At least $356.9 million in unclaimed state concessions a year — first systematic Australia-wide dollar estimate

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19 May 2026
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$356.9M per year

Australian households eligible for state-administered energy and water concessions leave at least AUD $356.9 million on the table every year across the five National Energy Customer Framework states plus Victoria's three-utility concession cluster. Estimate is a robust *lower bound*; see methodology notes below.

> Based on the most recent published systematic data: CPRC's 2022 analysis of DSS Payment Demographic Data (June 2022) and DVA Treatment Population (March 2022) administrative records, applied at current scheme rates. No more recent systematic estimate has been published.

KEY FINDINGS

- **More than 850,000 households across NECF states miss out on their state energy concession**; the figure rises to over 1.2 million household-concession-misses when Victoria's three utilities are counted separately. Three in every ten eligible households across the National Energy Customer Framework do not receive the energy concession they qualify for.
- **South Australia has the highest gap (38%) and Tasmania the lowest (19%)**. The NSW gap of 35% is independently corroborated by the NSW Government's own annual report at 36% — agreement within one percentage point across two independent sources.
- **Victorian renters are three times more likely to miss out on their water concession (22%) than their electricity concession (7%).** Same eligibility, same households, three-fold difference in take-up. The discrepancy was flagged by CPRC in 2022 and remains unresolved.

STATE-BY-STATE BREAKDOWN

JURISDICTION	CONCESSION	ELIGIBLE HH	NON-RECEIPT	PER HH / YR	UNCLAIMED / YR
NSW	Low Income Household Rebate (retail)	1,248,289	35%	$285	**$124.5M**
QLD	Electricity Rebate	875,914	29%	$386.34	**$98.1M**
SA	Energy Bill Concession	340,569	38%	$281.78	**$36.5M**
TAS	Annual Electricity Concession	115,308	19%	$645.56	**$14.1M**
ACT	Utilities Concession (elec + gas + water bundled)	41,407	31%	$800	**$10.3M**
VIC	Annual Electricity Concession (17.5% off bills)	989,936	7%	$262.50 *imputed*	**$18.2M**
VIC	Winter Gas Concession (17.5% May–Oct)	752,351	12%	$80 *imputed*	**$7.2M**
VIC	Water & Sewerage Concession (50%, cap $372.10)	871,143	22%	$250 *imputed*	**$47.9M**
TOTAL — NECF 5 STATES ELECTRICITY + VIC 3-UTILITY CLUSTER		**3,611,423**	—	—	**$356.9M**

> **Cross-source corroboration.** For the NSW Low Income Household Rebate — the largest single line at $124.5M — the NSW Department of Planning and Environment's own *NSW Energy Rebates Annual Report 2020-21* independently reports a 36% non-receipt rate, within one percentage point of CPRC's 35% NECF estimate. Two independent sources — one a state government administering the rebate, the other a Victorian-funded think tank — converge on the same finding.

HOW THIS ESTIMATE WAS PRODUCED

Each line is computed as *eligible households × non-receipt rate × per-household amount*. Eligible household counts use CPRC's 2022 analysis of DSS Payment Demographic Data with a 0.70 multi-card adjustment derived from the Victorian Utility Consumption Household Survey. Non-receipt rates use CPRC's modelling of Australian Energy Regulator retailer reporting (NECF states) and Department of Families, Fairness and Housing administrative data (Victoria). Per-household amounts are the current official scheme rates for fixed-rate concessions, and conservatively imputed reference values for percentage-rate concessions; both are documented in the full methodology.

Primary source — Consumer Policy Research Centre (CPRC), *Mind the Gap — Identifying the gap between energy concession eligibility and concessions received*, November 2022 (2022-11-09 update). Ben Martin Hobbs. cprc.org.au/report/mind-the-gap.

Eligible population — Department of Social Services, *Payment Demographic Data*, June 2022 vintage (per CPRC endnote 10). Department of Veterans' Affairs *Treatment Population*, March 2022.

Independent NSW corroboration — NSW Department of Planning and Environment, *NSW Energy Rebates Annual Report 2020-21*, p.4 (CPRC endnote 8).

Scope notes — Federal benefits (Age Pension, JobSeeker, FTB, CRA, etc.) are *not* included; methodology differs and is documented separately. Western Australia and the Northern Territory operate outside CPRC's NECF framework and are excluded. Non-energy state concessions (transport, rates, medical) lack equivalent published gap research and are excluded.

Full report and machine-readable CSV — `report/REPORT_V1.md`, `report/aggregates/headline_state_concessions.csv`, methodology `report/METHODOLOGY.md`. Branch `feature/unclaimed-report`.

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